

What Do You Actually Believe?

Six Sundays on Methodist belief and the traditions all around us

Sundays, 5:30 to 6:30 PM | West Campus | August 16 through September 27 No class September 6. Children's and youth programming meets at the same hour. Led by Woods Lisenby.

Most of us can say what we believe. Fewer of us could say why a Methodist says it differently than a Baptist down the road or a Catholic across town.

That is what these six weeks are for. Each Sunday takes up one core Christian belief, asks where Methodists land on it and why, then puts the same question to three traditions most of us already live next to. Roman Catholic. Southern Baptist and non-denominational. Reformed and Calvinist. Same three every week, so by the third Sunday you are not learning a new map, you are filling one in.

You will hear the strongest version of every position, including the ones we do not hold, because a disagreement is only worth having if you can state the other side accurately. **That is the one house rule.** Every tradition gets described the way it describes itself, not the way its critics describe it.

Come to any week you can. Every session stands on its own. No book, no homework. Bring a question.

The six weeks

August 16 | Who Knows and How How does God let himself be known, and when Christians disagree about what he said, who settles it? Rome has a teaching office that can settle a dispute. The Reformed have binding confessions. Baptists have neither, on principle. We have doctrinal standards most Methodists have never read.

August 23 | How Many Gods Are There? Christians say there is one God and then talk about three. This is the week we find what the whole family agrees on, since Catholics, Baptists, Presbyterians, and Methodists confess the same God. Then we look at the edge of the family, at the groups who knock on doors here and mean something different by the word.

August 30 | Who Gets Saved and How Has God already decided who will be saved? The oldest argument in Protestantism, and it is going on right now in churches down the road. You will learn the word prevenient, and you will hear the Calvinist case at full strength before we answer it.

September 13 | What the Cross Did What actually happened on the cross, and what happens inside a person who believes? The church has never officially settled on one explanation, which surprises most people. We also take up the question everybody here has been asked. Once saved, always saved?

September 20 | Means and End What is God doing at the font and the table, and how far can grace take a person in this life? This is the one week Methodists are not the moderate ones. Wesley believed a person can be so filled with love of God and neighbor that nothing else holds the center. Almost nobody else says that, and we will ask whether he was right.

September 27 | Practical Theology Doctrine is not decoration. Why our church has women pastors and some churches do not. Why your neighbor's church can fire its pastor and we cannot. And what a church is sent into the world to do, which these four traditions answer four different ways.

Two websites you can use all six weeks

Both are free, both work on a phone, and neither needs a login. Pull them up during class if you want.

theologybot.vercel.app

A map of my own theology, built from everything I have written and preached. Twenty-three doctrines are laid out as a connected structure, so you can see which beliefs hold up which other beliefs, and open any one of them to read a full explanation with the sermons and notes it came from. There is also an “Ask Me Anything” box that searches the whole body of work and answers with citations, so if you have wondered where I stand on something and did not want to ask in person, that is the place. It is useful in this class for one thing especially. When I say “here is where we stand,” you can go check whether I have been saying that consistently for twenty years.

theologycompare.vercel.app

The comparison tool this class is built around. It holds the traditions we will be discussing and lets you look at them several ways. A two-axis map scatters them by where they land on questions like sacraments and authority. A doctrine matrix puts the families side by side, belief by belief. A genealogy view shows how the branches actually split, from the early church through 1054 and 1517 and out into everything after. And an ask-and-compare box takes questions like how Methodist justification differs from Reformed. Every tradition on it is drawn from its own authoritative voice rather than from a critic’s summary.

If you want to read further

You do not need any of these. They are here because someone always asks.

Start here. Adam Hamilton, *Christianity’s Family Tree: What Other Christians Believe and Why*. A United Methodist pastor walking through the major traditions for ordinary readers. The closest thing in print to what this class is doing.

On the biggest argument in the class. Michael Horton, *For Calvinism*, and Roger Olson, *Against Calvinism*. Two scholars each making their own case at full strength, published together on purpose. Read them as a pair or the exercise is wasted.

On Methodism. Ted Campbell, *Methodist Doctrine: The Essentials*, is short and clear. Don Thorsen, *Calvin vs. Wesley*, does what its title says and is more readable than you would expect. Randy Maddox, *Responsible Grace*, is the serious scholarly treatment of Wesley, and a good deal of this class comes from it.

Free and primary. Wesley’s *A Plain Account of Christian Perfection* is online anywhere and is the source for week five. His sermon “Catholic Spirit” is short and is more or less the argument of this whole series. Our doctrinal standards are free at [umc.org](https://www.umc.org), in Part III of the Book of Discipline.

The other traditions in their own words. The Catechism of the Catholic Church at [usccb.org](https://www.usccb.org). The Baptist Faith and Message at [sbc.net](https://www.sbc.net). The Westminster Confession and the Heidelberg Catechism, both free online. Reading a tradition’s own statement before arguing with it is this whole class in one habit.

Questions between weeks? Ask me on a Sunday morning or send them along and I will work them into a session. The questions this room brings are usually better than the ones I plan.

The rest of this packet is a notes page for each week, in the order the class runs. Bring it back every Sunday.

Week 1 | August 16 | Who Knows and How

Revelation and authority

Tonight: *How does God let himself be known, and when Christians disagree about what he said, who settles it?*

Scriptures: Psalm 19:1-4 · Romans 1:18-23 · 2 Timothy 3:14-17 · Acts 15:1-21

Video: What Is the Bible? (5:48). What surprised you about how we got this book?

1 | How anybody knows anything about God

2 | Where we stand

3 | Where they stand, and the creeds question

Discussion, and what other people said

One question I still have

After class

On theologycompare.vercel.app: Genealogy view. Walk the branching from the early church through 1054 and 1517, and see where tonight's four traditions come from.

On theologybot.vercel.app: Open the **Revelation**, **Scripture**, and **Authority** nodes.

Ten minutes. Watch "The Story of the Bible" (5:38). If the Bible is one story rather than a rulebook, what changes about settling a disagreement from it?

Thirty minutes. Read the Articles of Religion, Part III of the Book of Discipline, free at [umc.org](https://www.umc.org). Twenty minutes, and most Methodists have never read them.

Bring back next week. One question about the Bible you have never felt comfortable asking out loud in a church building.

Week 2 | August 23 | How Many Gods Are There?

Trinity, Christology, and the Spirit's activity

Tonight: *Christians say there is one God and then talk about three. Which is it?*

Scriptures: Deuteronomy 6:4 · John 1:1-18 · Philippians 2:5-11 · Matthew 28:16-20 · John 16:12-15

Video: God (8:10). Did that solve the problem, or describe it more carefully?

1 | The problem, and what the church actually said

2 | Why it matters, and where we lean

3 | The edge of the family, and the Holy Spirit

Discussion, and what other people said

One question I still have

After class

On theologycompare.vercel.app: **Genealogy view**, and **Authors and leaders**, where Athanasius appears as the defender of Nicaea. The doctrine-of-God row is being added to the matrix and is not there yet.

On theologybot.vercel.app: Open the **God and Trinity** and **Christology** nodes. Ask: "What has Woods preached about the Trinity?"

Ten minutes. Watch "Holy Spirit" (4:11). Where in your own life would you say the Spirit has been at work, and how would you know?

Thirty minutes. Read the Nicene Creed a line at a time and look up what each line was written to rule out. It is a fighting document and reads differently once you know that.

Bring back next week. One question you have been asked by someone of another faith that you did not know how to answer.

Week 3 | August 30 | Who Gets Saved and How

Election, the will, prevenient grace, and the extent of the atonement

Tonight: *Does God choose, or do you?*

Scriptures: Ephesians 2:1-10 · John 6:44 · Romans 9:6-24 · 1 Timothy 2:3-6 · Titus 2:11

Video: Covenants (5:46). When God chooses somebody, what does he choose them for?

1 | The texts that cut both ways

2 | Prevenient grace, and what it costs us

3 | The other three, with the Reformed case at full strength

Discussion, and what other people said

One question I still have

After class

On theologycompare.vercel.app: **Two-axis map**, set to grace and the will. Watch the traditions scatter, and notice this is a spectrum rather than two camps. Keep tonight's four-question sheet beside it.

On theologybot.vercel.app: Open the **Grace** and **Salvation** nodes, then use **Ask and compare**: "how does Methodist election differ from Reformed?"

Ten minutes. Watch "Loyal Love" (5:11), on God's covenant loyalty given before it is deserved. Then read Luke 15:11-32. Who moves first, and how many times?

Thirty minutes. Read the Canons of Dort, free online, at least the first two heads. Read it as the tradition's own voice. That is the house rule practiced on the hardest case.

Bring back next week. Someone you know who believes differently about tonight's question, and one thing you admire about their faith.

Week 4 | September 13 | What the Cross Did

Atonement, justification, assurance, and whether you can lose it

Tonight: *What actually happened on the cross, and what actually happens in a person who believes?*

Scriptures: Isaiah 53:4-6 · Colossians 2:13-15 · Romans 3:21-28 · Romans 8:15-17 · Hebrews 6:4-8 · 1 John 5:11-13

Video: Sacrifice and Atonement (6:51). Did that match the answer you gave before we watched it?

1 | The cross, and the theories nobody told you about

2 | Justification, and what changes in a person

3 | Assurance, and whether you can lose it

Discussion, and what other people said

One question I still have

After class

On theologycompare.vercel.app: **Spectrum view**, set to salvation security. The most-asked question in Baldwin County, with all four traditions arranged on it.

On theologybot.vercel.app: Open the **Atonement**, **Justification**, and **Assurance** nodes. Ask: "Has Woods ever preached penal substitution?"

Ten minutes. Read Luke 15 all the way through, all three parables in a row. In each one, who does the searching?

Thirty minutes. Read the Joint Declaration on the Doctrine of Justification. Short and free online. Then ask what else we argue about that we have not read.

Bring back next week. A sentence about the cross you grew up hearing, that you are now not sure you believe.

Week 5 | September 20 | Means and End

Sacraments and sanctification

Tonight: *What is God doing at the font and at the table, and how far can grace take a person in this life?*

Scriptures: Romans 6:1-4 · Acts 2:38-39 · 1 Corinthians 11:23-29 · Matthew 5:43-48 · 1 Thessalonians 5:23-24 · 1 John 1:8-9

Video: Holiness (6:35). Was holiness in that video about behavior, or about something else?

1 | What a means of grace is, and the four models

2 | The font and the table

3 | Holiness, and the week we are the outlier

Discussion, and what other people said

One question I still have

After class

On [theologycompare.vercel.app](#): Doctrine matrix, the baptism and Lord's Supper rows. The two most visible differences in the series, and the ones you meet at a family funeral.

On [theologybot.vercel.app](#): Open the **Sacraments** and **Sanctification** nodes. Ask: "What has Woods said about the open table?"

Ten minutes. Watch "Water of Life" (4:57). If water is God's image for life given rather than earned, what does that suggest about baptizing someone who cannot yet ask?

Thirty minutes. Read Wesley's A Plain Account of Christian Perfection, free online, especially where he lists what he does not mean. Those misunderstandings are still ours.

Bring back next week. One question about baptism or communion you have wanted to ask for years and never asked.

Week 6 | September 27 | Practical Theology

Women in ministry, polity, and mission

Tonight: *Now that you know where everybody stands, what does it change about how a church works?*

Scriptures: Judges 4-5 · 2 Kings 22:14-20 · Acts 2:17-18 · Romans 16:1-7 · 1 Corinthians 14:34-35 · 1 Timothy 2:11-15 · Galatians 3:28

Video: Justice (6:18). Did that sound like evangelism, or like something else?

1 | Women in ministry

2 | Polity, and who is allowed to do what

3 | Mission, and what counts as done

Discussion, and what other people said

One question I still have

After class

On [theologycompare.vercel.app](#): Mind maps. Look at one tradition spun out whole, then another. After five weeks of single doctrines, see a whole system at once.

On [theologybot.vercel.app](#): Open the **Church**, **Women in Ministry**, and **Evangelism and Mission** nodes.

Ten minutes. Look back at the six weeks. What actually divides the church of Jesus Christ, and what is a matter on which Christians hold liberty?

Thirty minutes. Keep going. Adam Hamilton's Christianity's Family Tree, or Don Thorsen's Calvin vs. Wesley. Both sites stay up and stay free.

Bring back next week. Nothing. Come to the table.